

Aerosol Radiative Feedback and Optical Depth Parameterization over the Indo-Gangetic Plain: Resolving the Coarse-Mode Deficit and NO₂ Sink Dynamics

Introduction to Aerosol Radiative Feedback Modeling in the IGP

The Indo-Gangetic Plain (IGP) represents one of the most complex atmospheric environments on Earth, characterized by intense, multi-modal aerosol loadings that fluctuate drastically across seasons. Bounded by the towering Himalayas to the north and the Vindhyan and Satpura ranges to the south, the IGP forms a topographic trough that effectively traps both local anthropogenic pollution and advected natural aerosols¹. Estimating Aerosol Optical Depth (AOD) from surface particulate matter (PM) concentrations via fitted log-log elasticities is a standard mechanism in chemical transport models and radiative feedback architectures (such as those utilizing Copernicus Atmosphere Monitoring Service, or CAMS, data). However,

deriving column AOD exclusively from surface fine particulate matter ($PM_{2.5}$) introduces profound structural biases.

By excluding the coarse-mode mineral dust fraction—specifically particles in the 2.5 to $10\mu m$ aerodynamic diameter range ($PM_{10-2.5}$)—the return path of radiative forcing is severely compromised. This blind spot is particularly catastrophic during the pre-monsoon season, when massive dust transport from the Thar Desert and the Arabian Peninsula dictates the optical state of the troposphere. When a radiative feedback model limits its optical depth derivation to a $PM_{2.5}$ -based elasticity (e.g., $AOD \approx a \cdot PM_{2.5}^b$), it operates on the implicit, erroneous assumption that the fine-mode fraction (FMF) dominates total extinction uniformly throughout the year, or that coarse-mode variance perfectly correlates with fine-mode variance. Over the IGP, neither assumption holds true¹.

The temporal uncoupling of anthropogenic combustion emissions (which peak in winter under shallow, stagnant boundary layers) and mineral dust transport (which peaks in the pre-monsoon under deep convective boundary layers) renders a univariant fine-mode parameterization mathematically and physically indefensible for annualized climate modeling. The failure to capture coarse dust alters the simulated regional surface energy balance, suppressing the modeled atmospheric heating and surface dimming that govern the

thermodynamic gradients necessary for accurately forecasting meteorological phenomena, including the Indian Summer Monsoon⁴.

This comprehensive report provides an architectural framework for restructuring aerosol optical depth parameterizations over the IGP. It systematically delineates the seasonal fine versus coarse contributions to AOD, defines the microphysical and optical properties (Mass Extinction Efficiency, Single-Scattering Albedo, Asymmetry Parameter) of both modes at the reference wavelength of $550nm$, and establishes a defensible, bounded bivariate elasticity model incorporating a specific $PM_{10} - PM_{2.5}$ term. Furthermore, it addresses the differential application of hygroscopic growth factors across aerosol modes and resolves secondary atmospheric chemistry queries regarding nitrogen dioxide (NO_2) photolytic sink dynamics under dense winter haze.

Seasonal Apportionment of Aerosol Optical Depth over the IGP

To accurately quantify the magnitude of the error introduced by omitting the coarse mode, the seasonal oscillation of the Fine Mode Fraction (FMF) and the Angstrom Exponent (AE, or α) over Delhi and the broader IGP must be evaluated. Ground-based remote sensing networks, primarily the Aerosol Robotic Network (AERONET), alongside satellite retrievals from MODIS and MISR, demonstrate that the IGP is subjected to two distinct, highly concentrated aerosol regimes that alternate dominance throughout the year.

The Winter Combustion Regime: Fine-Mode Dominance

During the winter months (December to February), the meteorology of the IGP is governed by subsidence, minimal precipitation, low wind speeds, and a highly stable, shallow atmospheric

boundary layer that frequently drops below $1km$ in altitude¹. These stagnant atmospheric conditions trap local anthropogenic emissions near the surface, leading to the accumulation of vehicular exhaust, industrial effluents, and extensive biomass, biofuel, and agricultural stubble burning².

AERONET climatological data from sites such as Kanpur, Greater Noida, and Delhi indicate that wintertime AOD at $500nm$ is persistently high, typically averaging between 0.50 and 0.87

⁷. During this period, the Angstrom Exponent ($\alpha_{440-870}$), which serves as an inverse proxy for particle size, frequently exceeds 1.1 to 1.26 , indicating the overwhelming dominance of fine-mode accumulation particles⁷. The Fine Mode Fraction (FMF) of total AOD reaches its annual maximum during these months, typically accounting for 50% to 80% of the total aerosol volume and extinction³.

Consequently, during the winter season, a $PM_{2.5}$ -based log-log elasticity model performs

reasonably well. The optical depth is primarily driven by accumulation-mode combustion aerosols, and the vertical profile is compressed, strengthening the correlation between surface PM measurements and column AOD⁹. The omission of the coarse mode during winter results in a relatively marginal underestimation of AOD, as resuspended road dust and soil contribute minimally to the total column extinction under the prevailing low-wind conditions.

The Pre-Monsoon Dust Regime: Coarse-Mode Dominance

The transition into the pre-monsoon season (March to June) radically alters the aerosol climatology of the region. Increasing surface temperatures induce intense dry convection, expanding the boundary layer height up to 3 to 4km ⁶. Simultaneously, strong southwesterly and westerly winds transport massive quantities of mineral dust from the Thar Desert, the Arabian Peninsula, and arid regions in Pakistan across the entire IGP².

During the pre-monsoon period, total AOD escalates significantly, often averaging 0.60 to 0.90 , with peak dust storm events routinely driving AOD well above 1.0 ⁴. However, the microphysical composition of the atmospheric column shifts drastically away from anthropogenic dominance. The Angstrom Exponent drops sharply to values typically < 0.6 , and often plunges to 0.38 during severe dust outbreaks⁴. Correspondingly, the Fine Mode Fraction plummets. AERONET inversions over Kanpur and Delhi show that the FMF drops to between 0.08 and 0.25 during the pre-monsoon, meaning that 75% to 92% of the aerosol volume is concentrated in the coarse mode (aerodynamic diameters $> 1\mu\text{m}$)³.

This seasonal inversion exposes the critical structural flaw in a $PM_{2.5}$ -exclusive AOD parameterization. While surface PM_{10} concentrations routinely exceed 500 to $950\mu\text{g}/\text{m}^3$ during pre-monsoon dust events, the $PM_{2.5}$ fraction remains comparatively low¹³. If the radiative feedback model solely extrapolates column extinction from $PM_{2.5}$, it remains entirely blind to the vast, optically thick column of mineral dust dominating the upper boundary layer, effectively truncating the simulated radiative forcing and misrepresenting the regional climate dynamics.

The Quantitative Error of a Fine-Only AOD Assumption

Excluding mineral dust from the radiative return path over the IGP results in highly asymmetric seasonal errors. Based on the volumetric fractions and extinction contributions derived from AERONET, MISR, and regional modeling climatology, the percentage error in calculated AOD when omitting the coarse fraction is quantifiable.

For the purposes of honest reporting, if the fine-only parameterization is left unfixed, the modeler must disclose the following systemic underestimations:

1. **Winter Error (Dec-Feb):** The fine-only error is roughly 15% to 25% . While fine

particles dominate the optical column, a persistent background of coarse resuspended dust still contributes to total extinction³.

2. **Pre-Monsoon Error (Mar-Jun):** The fine-only error scales catastrophically to 60% to 75%. A model deriving AOD only from $PM_{2.5}$ will capture less than one-third of the actual shortwave extinction occurring in the atmospheric column during dust events³.
3. **Annualized Average Error:** Over a full simulation year, relying exclusively on a $PM_{2.5}$ elasticity model will yield a systematic underestimation of total AOD by approximately 35% to 45% over the IGP³.

This is not merely a statistical artifact; it represents missing atmospheric physics. Atmosphere models that miss coarse dust underestimate the radiative warming caused by longwave absorption, leading to an overall reduction in the simulated global all-dust radiative cooling, or misrepresenting the vertical heating profile¹⁴. Over the IGP, this vertical heating acts as an "elevated heat pump," which alters monsoonal circulation and precipitation patterns⁴.

Microphysical and Optical Properties by Aerosol Mode at 550 nm

To defensibly correct the parameterization, the model must recognize that fine combustion aerosols and coarse mineral dust possess fundamentally different optical signatures. These signatures dictate how physical mass translates into optical extinction, and how that extinction subsequently influences the radiative transfer equations via the partitioning of absorption and directional scattering. The three paramount parameters at the standard reference wavelength of 550nm are the Mass Extinction Efficiency (MEE), the Single-Scattering Albedo (SSA), and the Asymmetry Parameter (g).

Mass Extinction Efficiency (MEE)

The Mass Extinction Efficiency (m^2/g) defines the total light extinction (scattering plus absorption) per unit mass of the aerosol. It serves as the mathematical bridge between chemical transport mass outputs (PM concentrations) and optical depth (AOD). According to

Mie scattering theory, MEE is heavily dependent on the size parameter ($x = 2\pi r/\lambda$).

Because the radii of $PM_{2.5}$ particles fall largely within the optimal scattering regime for visible light ($\lambda = 550nm$, where $x \approx 1$), their extinction per unit mass is exceptionally high. Conversely, coarse dust particles reside in the geometric scattering regime, where MEE is inversely proportional to particle radius and density, resulting in much lower efficiency per unit of mass.

Fine Combustion Aerosol ($PM_{2.5}$): Over urban centers like Delhi, the MEE for fine-mode

aerosols at $550nm$ typically ranges from 3.5 to $6.6m^2/g$, with a highly defensible central tendency of $4.40 \pm 0.84m^2/g$ ¹⁵. It is critical to note that MEE is not perfectly static; it exhibits a negative correlation with mass concentration. As $PM_{2.5}$ mass concentrations reach extreme levels ($> 150\mu g/m^3$) during severe winter pollution episodes, rapid particle coagulation shifts the median radius upward. This process leads to a saturation of scattering efficiency, causing the MEE to slightly decrease toward $3.0 - 5.0m^2/g$ ¹⁵. This sub-linear scaling represents the physical justification for using a fractional exponent in log-log elasticity models, rather than a strictly linear multiplier.

Coarse Mineral Dust ($PM_{10-2.5}$): The MEE for coarse-mode mineral dust at $550nm$ is substantially lower. Because coarse dust particles are physically massive, they contribute heavily to PM mass loading but relatively less to visible light extinction per gram compared to fine particles. Global aerosol models and empirical constraints utilizing AERONET inversions place the MEE of coarse dust strictly between 0.5 and $1.2m^2/g$ ¹⁶. Using a proxy where coarse dust is treated with fine-mode MEE properties would result in unphysical, massive overestimations of AOD during the pre-monsoon.

Single-Scattering Albedo (SSA) and Asymmetry Parameter (g)

The Single-Scattering Albedo (SSA, or ω_0) dictates the ratio of scattering to total extinction, effectively governing atmospheric heating rates. An SSA of 1.0 implies pure scattering, while lower values denote increasing absorption. The Asymmetry Parameter (g) quantifies the preferred direction of scattered light, where $g = 1$ is entirely forward scattering, $g = 0$ is isotropic, and $g = -1$ is backward scattering.

Fine Combustion Aerosol: Due to high concentrations of Black Carbon (BC) and light-absorbing organic carbon (brown carbon) emitted from vehicular exhaust, brick kilns, and biomass burning in the IGP, the fine-mode SSA at $550nm$ is relatively low. During winter, SSA typically ranges from 0.80 to 0.89 ¹⁸. This indicates strong absorption and high localized atmospheric heating within the shallow boundary layer. Because fine particles are closer in size to the wavelength of light, they scatter light more isotropically than large particles, resulting in an asymmetry parameter g between 0.60 and 0.65 ¹⁷.

Coarse Mineral Dust: Mineral dust originating from the Thar desert and Arabian Peninsula is largely scattering at $550nm$, though weak absorption occurs due to the presence of trace iron oxides (such as hematite and goethite). The SSA for the coarse dust mode is notably higher

than the combustion mode, typically ranging between 0.92 and 0.96 (with a defensible mean of 0.95) at $550nm$ ¹⁸. Because coarse particles are physically large compared to the wavelength of visible light, diffraction dominates the scattering phase function, resulting in highly forward-directional scattering. Consequently, the asymmetry parameter g for coarse dust is tightly bounded between 0.70 and 0.75 ¹⁷.

Optical Parameter at 550 nm	Fine Mode (Combustion/Urban)	Coarse Mode (Mineral Dust)
Dominant Season in IGP	Winter / Post-Monsoon	Pre-Monsoon / Monsoon
Mass Extinction Efficiency (MEE)	$3.5 - 6.6m^2/g$ (Mean: 4.4)	$0.5 - 1.2m^2/g$ (Mean: 0.85)
Single-Scattering Albedo (SSA)	$0.80 - 0.89$	$0.92 - 0.96$
Asymmetry Parameter (g)	$0.60 - 0.65$	$0.70 - 0.75$

Formulating a Bounded Bimodal AOD-PM Elasticity Model

To rectify the coarse-mode exclusion, the total column AOD must be modeled as the linear superposition of fine-mode extinction and coarse-mode extinction. Since optical depth is fundamentally an additive property of independent atmospheric constituents, a univariant

log-log fit ($AOD = \exp(a \cdot \ln(PM_{2.5}) + b)$) is a mathematical misrepresentation of a bimodal physical system.

Defensibility of the Bimodal Approach

Extensive literature on satellite-to-surface PM conversion demonstrates that multi-variate regression models, specifically linear mixed-effect (LME) models, geographically weighted regressions, and advanced machine learning algorithms (e.g., LightGBM, Random Forest),

significantly outperform univariant $PM_{2.5}$ models¹⁰. Studies leveraging paired MODIS AOD

and ground-based PM data in the IGP explicitly partition the total mass into $PM_{2.5}$ and PM_{10} to account for the differential MEEs and varying vertical scale heights¹⁰. Using the mass difference metric, $PM_{coarse} = PM_{10} - PM_{2.5}$, as an independent variable perfectly isolates the mineral dust and mechanically resuspended fractions from the combustion fractions¹⁵.

Therefore, migrating from a single-term elasticity to a bimodal elasticity equation is not only defensible, it is the scientifically expected standard for models resolving aerosol radiative effects over dust-prone topographies¹⁶.

Recommended Parameterization and Coefficient Derivations

The column AOD at $550nm$ should be approximated by the following functional form:

$$AOD_{550} \approx a \cdot (PM_{2.5})^b \cdot f_{fine}(RH) + c \cdot (PM_{10} - PM_{2.5})^d \cdot f_{coarse}(RH)$$

In this equation:

- a and c are scaling pre-factors that implicitly embed the baseline Mass Extinction Efficiency of the respective aerosol modes and the average effective scale height (H_{eff}) of the layers.
- b and d are the elasticity coefficients that account for sub-linear or super-linear scaling due to concentration-driven coagulation or boundary layer dilution.
- $f_{fine}(RH)$ and $f_{coarse}(RH)$ are the mode-specific hygroscopic growth factors.

Bounding the Coefficients

The literature provides clear bounds for these parameters over the IGP based on statistical regression analyses and physical optics¹⁰:

1. **Fine-Mode Elasticity (b):** The exponent b for $PM_{2.5}$ generally sits slightly below unity. As $PM_{2.5}$ mass increases to severe levels in Delhi (often exceeding $300\mu g/m^3$), the particle size distribution shifts upward via rapid coagulation. This slight increase in effective radius moves the particles past the optimal Mie scattering peak, marginally decreasing the MEE¹⁵. Thus, b should be bounded between **0.75 and 0.95**.
2. **Coarse-Mode Elasticity (d):** The exponent d for coarse dust is typically closer to

perfect linearity. Coarse particles do not rapidly coagulate in the same manner as accumulation-mode aerosols, and their size distribution remains more stable across varying mass concentrations. The value for d should be bounded between 0.85 and 1.00.

3. **Fine-Mode Pre-factor (a):** The pre-factors govern the baseline translation of mass to optical depth. Because the MEE of fine particles is roughly 4 to 5 times greater than that of coarse particles, the coefficient a will structurally be larger than c . However, this is partially offset by the fact that the winter fine-mode scale height is shallow, whereas pre-monsoon dust layers are deep. Based on regional LME regression studies over the IGP mapping AOD to surface PM¹⁰, a typically ranges from 0.003 to 0.015.
4. **Coarse-Mode Pre-factor (c):** Reflecting the low MEE of coarse dust ($0.85m^2/\zeta$), the pre-factor c is smaller, though its magnitude is buoyed by the deep convective mixing depth of the pre-monsoon atmosphere. Regression analyses bound c strictly between 0.0005 and 0.002¹⁰.

Parameter	Physical Representation	Defensible Bounded Range	Justification / Citations
b	Fine-mode mass elasticity	0.75 $\leftrightarrow$	Sub-linear scaling due to accumulation-mode coagulation lowering MEE at high mass concentrations ¹⁵ .
d	Coarse-mode mass elasticity	0.85 $\leftrightarrow$	Near-linear scaling; stable size distribution for mechanically generated and advected dust ¹⁰ .
a	Fine-mode pre-factor	0.003 $\leftrightarrow$	Reflects high MEE ($4.4m^2/\zeta$)

			coupled with the characteristically shallow winter mixing scale height ¹⁰ .
<i>c</i>	Coarse-mode pre-factor	0.0005 ↔	Reflects lower MEE ($0.85m^2/\zeta$) distributed across a deeper convective pre-monsoon scale height ¹⁶ .

Hygroscopic Growth Factor Corrections for the IGP

A critical component of bridging dry surface mass outputs to ambient optical depth is

accounting for water uptake by aerosols. The hygroscopic growth factor, $f(RH)$, defines the ratio of the aerosol scattering coefficient at a given ambient Relative Humidity (RH) to its dry state. Applying a single, uniform $f(RH)$ curve to bulk PM_{10} is a severe mechanistic error over the IGP, as the hygroscopicity of fine and coarse particles diverges completely.

If the model previously applied the fine-mode $f(RH)$ correction to a proxy that included coarse mass, it would have artificially inflated the AOD during the pre-monsoon and monsoon seasons by upwards of 100% to 150%.

Fine-Mode Hygroscopicity: The Soluble Fraction

The fine mode ($PM_{2.5}$) in the IGP is highly hygroscopic. It is heavily composed of secondary water-soluble inorganic salts—such as sulfates, nitrates, and ammonium—as well as oxidized organic compounds⁸. As relative humidity surpasses the deliquescence point of these salts, the particles rapidly take up water, swelling in size and vastly increasing their optical scattering cross-section.

For the IGP, the empirical γ -power law is widely utilized in operational models:

$$f_{fine}(RH) = \left(1 - \frac{RH}{100}\right)^{-\gamma}$$

For fine combustion aerosols over urban India, the parameter γ ranges from 0.40 to 0.60.

This yields a substantial growth factor; at an $RH = 80\%$, the $f_{fine}(RH)$ typically reaches **2.2 to 2.8** (with a defensible mean of 2.63 ± 0.45)¹⁵. Consequently, the extreme AOD spikes observed over Delhi during winter mornings are often driven as much by hygroscopic swelling in fog conditions as they are by the underlying dry particulate mass²³.

Coarse-Mode Hydrophobicity: The Mineral Fraction

In stark contrast, the coarse mode ($PM_{10-2.5}$) in this region is overwhelmingly composed of insoluble mineral dust, primarily silicates, aluminosilicates, and calcium carbonates⁶. Mineral dust is highly hydrophobic. It does not undergo deliquescence and exhibits negligible water uptake even at elevated relative humidities approaching saturation. For coarse mineral dust over the IGP, the hygroscopic growth correction is strictly close to unity:

$$f_{coarse}(RH) \approx 1.0$$

To maintain mathematical continuity within the model, a γ parameter for the coarse mode can be bounded between **0.00 and 0.05**, which yields an $f(RH)$ bounded practically between **1.00 and 1.05** at $RH = 80\%$ ¹⁵. Separating these terms ensures that the massive PM_{10} spikes during pre-monsoon dust storms are correctly interpreted by the radiative feedback module as dry, non-swelling extinction events.

NO₂ Accumulation Dynamics and Photolytic Sinks under Winter Haze

Addressing the secondary query regarding the atmospheric chemistry of Nitrogen Dioxide (NO₂): The current model evaluates NO₂ accumulation under haze utilizing the expression

$$1/(1 - \phi(1 - a))$$

, where ' a ' is the surviving fraction of the photolysis rate $J(NO_2)$

due to haze attenuation, and ϕ represents the share of total NO₂ loss that proceeds via photolysis.

The baseline assumption of $\phi = 0.7$ is heavily biased toward clear-sky, summer, or mid-latitude urban daytime regimes, where the primary loss mechanism is homogeneous gas-phase photochemistry. In the specific context of Delhi during the daytime winter season, extreme haze fundamentally restructures NO_x partitioning, invalidating the **0.7** assumption.

The Suppression of Photolysis in Delhi Winter

In standard daytime photochemistry, NO_2 is lost through two primary pathways:

1. **Photolysis:** $\text{NO}_2 + h\nu \rightarrow \text{NO} + \text{O}$ (which rapidly cycles with molecular oxygen to form ozone).
2. **Hydroxyl Radical Sink:** $\text{NO}_2 + \text{OH} + \text{M} \rightarrow \text{HNO}_3 + \text{M}$.

However, during Delhi winter haze events, the actinic flux ($h\nu$) in the UV-A spectrum (300 – 400nm) is severely attenuated, dropping $J(\text{NO}_2)$ to a fraction of its clear-sky value¹⁸. Because the production of the hydroxyl radical (OH) is itself tightly coupled to photolysis (specifically the photolysis of ozone to $\text{O}(^1\text{D})$ followed by reaction with water vapor), the extreme dimming suppresses the entire gas-phase photolytic engine²⁴.

If photolysis and OH reactions both slow down proportionally, one might assume ϕ remains stable. However, a third, massive competing sink emerges during winter haze: heterogeneous hydrolysis on aerosol surfaces.

The Dominance of Heterogeneous Competing Sinks

The winter boundary layer in Delhi is characterized by extraordinary aerosol surface area concentrations and low temperatures, which drives NO_X chemistry toward the heterogeneous uptake of Dinitrogen Pentoxide (N_2O_5).



While the nitrate radical (NO_3) is rapidly photolyzed during a normal day, the extreme attenuation of sunlight under winter haze, combined with short daytime hours and high aerosol surface area, allows the heterogeneous N_2O_5 sink to persistently drain the NO_X pool not just at night, but deep into the morning and late afternoon hours. Furthermore, the direct heterogeneous uptake of NO_2 onto wet aerosol surfaces and soot (forming HONO and HNO_3) becomes a highly competitive daytime sink when the particulate mass exceeds

$200\mu g/m^3$ ²⁴.

Defensible Range for the Photolytic Share (ϕ)

Because the heterogeneous sinks (which are non-photolytic) account for an abnormally large fraction of NO_x removal during extreme haze, the photolytic share ϕ is radically compressed.

Under typical clear-sky conditions, photolysis accounts for roughly 70% of the sink, OH accounts for roughly 25%, and heterogeneous sinks account for 5%. Under severe Delhi winter haze (visibility $< 1km$), the massive available aqueous aerosol surface area accelerates the N_2O_5 and direct NO_2 uptake mechanisms so heavily that heterogeneous sinks account for 40% to 50% of the total daytime NO_2 loss. The OH radical sink drops to roughly 10%, and photolysis accounts for the remaining 40% to 50% ²⁴.

Therefore, for a Delhi winter daytime specifically, the defensible range for ϕ drops from the assumed 0.70 down to $0.40 \leq \phi \leq 0.55$.

Using $\phi = 0.7$ under these conditions would vastly underestimate NO_2 accumulation by artificially assuming the photolytic engine is still dominating the sink pathways. By bounding ϕ between 0.40 and 0.55, the model accurately reflects the shift from gas-phase photochemistry to heterogeneous aerosol-phase chemistry that defines the Delhi winter atmosphere.

Synthesis and Conclusion

To defensibly correct the radiative feedback model, the univariant $PM_{2.5}$ elasticity must be retired. The transition to a bivariate model isolating $PM_{2.5}$ and $PM_{10-2.5}$ ensures that the radiative forcing of pre-monsoon dust is captured accurately, eliminating a systemic 60% to 75% underestimation of AOD during the spring, and a $\sim 35\%$ to 45% underestimation annually.

By implementing the parameterized bounds provided for mass elasticity (b, d), pre-factors (a, c), hygroscopic growth curves (γ), and photolytic loss share (ϕ), the model will accurately simulate both the intense, highly absorbing, localized heating of the winter combustion regime, and the deep, forward-scattering, surface-dimming properties of the pre-monsoon dust

regime across the Indo-Gangetic Plain.

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